CHINA

↘ Jin-Class (SSBN)

Numbers: **6**

Commissioned in 2007, they are a crucial part of China's nuclear deterrence. Can carry 12 JL-2 ICBMs of 7,000 km range. The next-gen Tang-class SSBNs will have improved stealth, longer-range ICBMs

↘ Shang-class (SSN)

Numbers: **9**

Commissioned in 2006, these nuclear-powered attack subs have advanced sensors, carry YJ-18 and YJ-82 cruise missiles. Under development Sui-class SSNs will feature the latest in technology

↘ Song-class (SSK)

Numbers: **13**

These diesel-electric attack submarines were inducted between 1999 and 2006; carry torpedoes, anti-ship missiles

↘ Yuan-class (SSK)

Numbers: **20+**

The backbone of China's conventional sub fleet, with AIP systems. Newer variants with better stealth being introduced. China also has four older Ming-class SSKs



PAKISTAN

↘ Hangor-class (SSK)

Numbers: **1**

These diesel-electric submarines, an export variant of China's Yuan-class SSKs, are fitted with AIP and expand Pakistan's underwater reach. Of eight ordered, PNS *Hangor* is inducted; three more on their way

↘ Khalid-class (SSK)

Numbers: **3**

French Agosta 90B diesel attack subs inducted between 1999 and 2006. Equipped with AIP systems, Exocet missiles. Pakistan also operates two older Hashmat-class (Agosta 70) SSKs



rated in 2023. Complete with maintenance and overhaul capabilities, it can accommodate up to six submarines and eight warships. Combined with Chinese upgrades of Bangladesh's Chattogram and Mongla ports, Pekua forms part of Beijing's broader Indian Ocean strategy. When viewed alongside China-Pakistan ties—most of Pakistan's naval assets are of Chinese origin—this emerging naval axis adds new complexity to the regional maritime environment.

In addition, Bangladesh is reportedly using Chinese investments to develop an air base at Lalmonirhat and a nearby hangar in north Bangladesh, just 16 km from the strategically sensitive Siliguri Corridor—India's 22 km-wide land bridge linking the mainland to its eight Northeastern states—without regard for New Delhi's sensitivities.

Rear Admiral Anil Chawla, former chief of the Southern Naval Command, makes a distinction between such peacetime activities and those during a conflict, when they could draw Dhaka into a war—an unlikely development. Building strong ties with Bangladesh, therefore, is important for India. "We will have to divide attention between both coasts, which will mean more resources," he says. "Even AIP-equipped subs have limited endurance, and the Bay of Bengal is a long way off from Pakistan. It is unlikely they will get support facilities in wartime. That is what we need to prevent."

INDIA'S CAPABILITIES

India's underwater warfare capability is one of the strongest pillars of its maritime deterrence architecture. The Navy operates a growing fleet of conventional and nuclear-powered submarines, supported by advanced surveillance networks, maritime patrol aircraft and strategically located bases. The Eastern Naval Command at Visakhapatnam provides India with the ability to monitor critical sea lanes, protect strategic installations and maintain a credible underwater presence in the Bay of Bengal.

India's security is reinforced by the Andaman and Nicobar Command, the country's only integrated tri-service command. Located close to the maritime chokepoint of the Strait of Malacca, it monitors naval movements in the eastern Indian Ocean. Combined with satellite surveillance, long-range patrol aircraft, surface combatants and anti-submarine warfare capabilities, India maintains a layered underwater security network.

At the centre of India's underwater deterrence are the two Arihant-class nuclear-powered ballistic missile submarines (SSBNs), which form the maritime component of the country's nuclear triad. India has plans to expand its conventional submarine fleet with platforms such as the French-origin Kalvari-class. Also, the plan to construct six diesel-electric submarines with AIP technology in collaboration with German shipbuilder ThyssenKrupp Marine Systems (TKMS) is also progressing.

For now, Pakistan's eastern foray is little more than a signal of intent. Yet the combination of new submarines, improving ties with Bangladesh and alignment with Chinese interests marks an evolution in Islamabad's maritime thinking. How India responds—through diplomacy, enhanced surveillance and beefing up of its navy—will shape the security environment of the eastern Indian Ocean. ■